

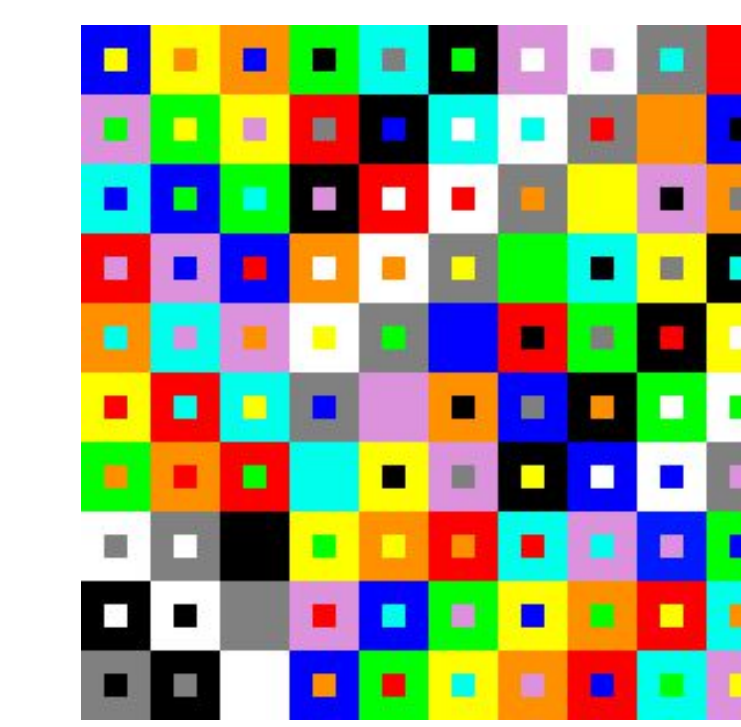


Boys' Love: The Evolutionary Dynamics, Strategies and Socio-Economic Capacity of Thailand's BL Media Industry

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Introduction

- The boys love genre has gained significant traction in Thailand since the early 2010.
- By 2020, LINE TV reported nearly 19 billion views of BL ¹ series on its platform alone, and the industry has continued to grow at a rate of 17% annually².
- Production companies are not only competing to capture revenue, but are also differentiating their content through marketing strategies and thematic choices.
- While some series lean into commercialized fantasies catering to broader audiences, others focus on portraying more authentic queer narratives that resonate with local or LGBTQ+ viewers.
- There is a tension between profitability and representation, raising questions about how industry players navigate market pressures.
- Our project seeks to understand how different BL productions compete in this ever-evolving industry. By analyzing marketing strategies and production choices, we hope to find strategic behaviors and decisions that shape the BL market in Thailand today.



Derivations of Methods

We modeled the frequency of audiences choosing authentic (C) versus fantasy (D) representations in BL media using replicator dynamics:

$$\dot{x} = x(1-x)(f_C - f_D)$$

where $x \in [0, 1]$ represents the proportion favoring authenticity.

The fitness for each strategy are determined by reputation-weighted support from two groups:

- LGBTQ+ members ($N = 0.08$)
- Non-members ($M = 0.92$)

where γ represents the *care factor*, the degree to which non-members reward authenticity.

The reputation-based probabilities p and q reflect the likelihood of choosing authentic content in each group:

$$p = \frac{r_C}{r_C + r_D}, \quad q = \frac{\varphi_C}{\varphi_C + \varphi_D}$$

Methods

Reputation values evolve with audience exposure and are modeled using exponential and decay functions:

For LGBTQ+ members:

$$r_C = \alpha_C e^{(1-x)t}, \text{ with } \alpha_C = 0.6$$

$$r_D = \alpha_D e^{(x-1)t}, \text{ with } \alpha_D = 0.4$$

For non-members:

$$\varphi_C = \beta_C e^{(x-1)t}, \text{ with } \beta_C = 0.3$$

$$\varphi_D = \beta_D e^{(1-x)t}, \text{ with } \beta_D = 0.7$$

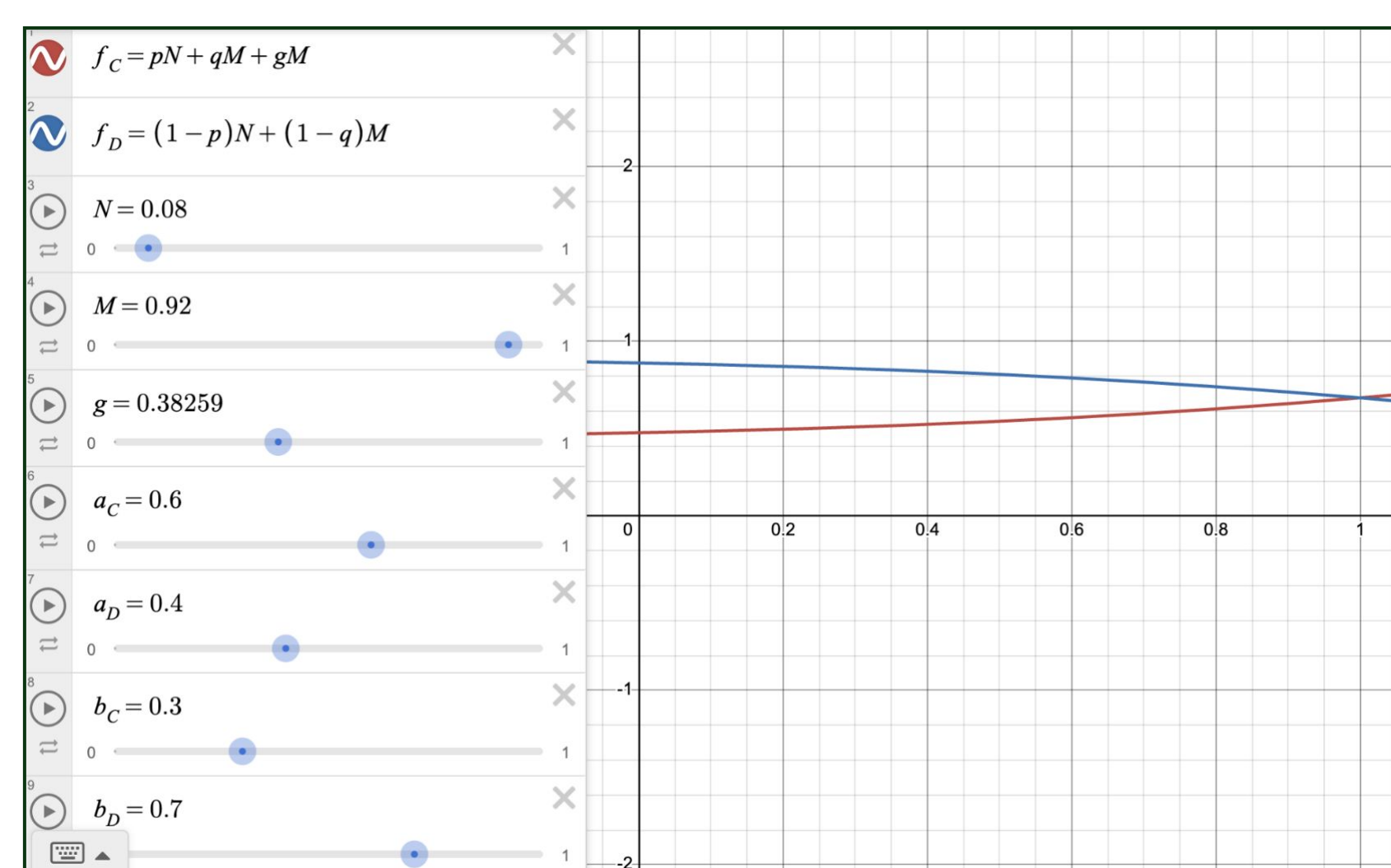
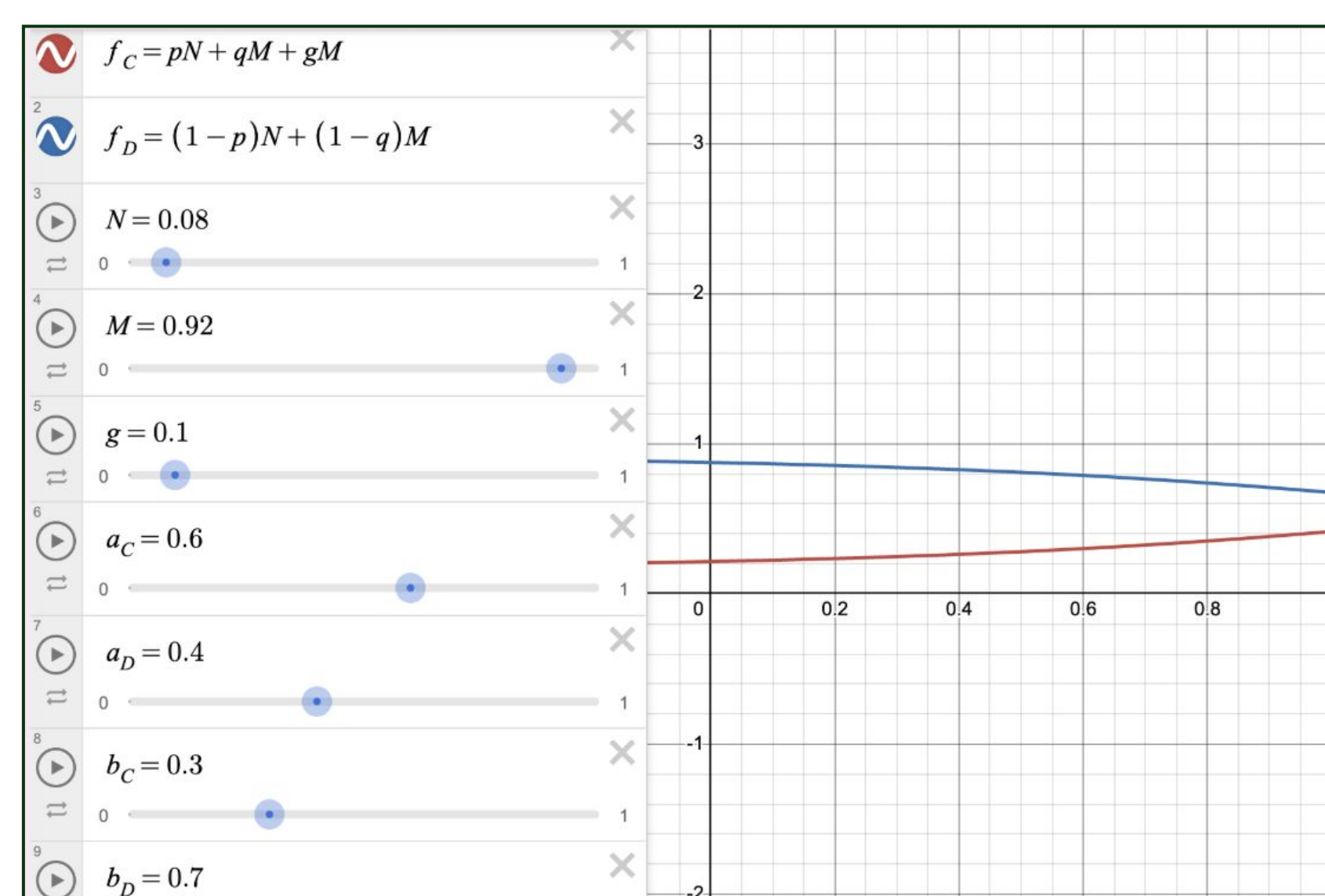
Time is set at $t = 1$, and all dynamics are simulated across these parameters to analyze the evolution of media preference.

Variables

x : frequency of authentic (C) vs. fantasy (D)
 $f_{C,D}$: fitness of authentic (C) vs. fantasy (D)
 N : # of audience members in the LGBTQ+ community
 M : # of audience members not in the LGBTQ+ community
 p : probability of N choosing C
 q : probability of M choosing C
 γ : care factor for N in C
 $r_{C,D}$: reputation of C/D in N
 $\varphi_{C,D}$: reputation of C/D in M
 $\alpha_{C,D}$: initial reputation of C/D in N
 $\beta_{C,D}$: initial reputation of C/D in M

Results

Payoff Functions (F_C and F_D) vs. Frequency of Authentic (x)



Key Findings

Critical threshold for authenticity at 0.38

- Advantage point for defection; f_C and f_D cross at 1
- When $\gamma > 0.38$, authentic narratives (C) dominate
- Otherwise, commercial narratives (D) dominate

Authentic (C) vs. Fantasy (D) Dominance: Graphs show which strategy has a higher "payoff" (f_C vs. f_D) at different frequencies (x),

If $f_D > f_C$ ($\Delta f < 0$), fantasy (D) grows

Ex. at $x = 0.2$, $f_C \approx 0.612$, $f_D \approx 0.738$, $\Delta f \approx -0.126$

Payoffs are determined by reputation-weighted support from LGBTQ+ members and non-members

- Δf : The Deciding Factor: If $F_C > F_D$ ($\Delta f > 0$), authentic narratives (C) grow

r_C , the payoff of authentic narratives, decreases as frequency of authentic narratives increases

- Positive exponential function within population of LGBTQ+ community as they support it
- Reputation of authentic narrative (C) is higher than its payoff r_D , the payoff of fantasy narratives, increases decreases as frequency of authentic narratives increases
- Reputation of fantasy narrative (D) is lower than its payoff
- Reputation of fantasy narrative is a decay function since the trend of choosing fantasy narratives hurts reputation of (C)

Reputation Variables (p , q , r_C , r_D , ϕ_C , ϕ_D) vs. Frequency of Authentic (x)



Discussion

- Difficult for mainstream audiences to appreciate authentic queer narratives
- Growth of BL still has some positive implications
 - Normalizes queer relationships to the public
 - Thailand first Southeast Asian country to normalize queer marriage
- The commercial success of a fantasy narrative does not imply a lack of societal progress
- Implications
 - Members of the queer community has to push for authentic portrayals
 - Production should shift to slowly incorporate accurate narratives amongst the traditional fantasy storyline

References

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